

1. Research Objectives, Research Method, etc.

This research proposal will be reviewed in the Basic Section of the applicant's choice. In filling this application form, refer to the Application Procedures for Grants-in-Aid for Scientific Research -KAKENHI-.

Research objectives, research method, etc. should be described within 4 pages. A succinct summary of the research proposal should be given at the beginning. The main text should give descriptions, in concrete and clear terms, of (1) scientific background of the proposed research, the circumstances leading to the conception of the proposed research, and the "key scientific question" comprising the core of the research plan, (2) the purpose, scientific originality, and creativity of the research project, (3) research trends in the relevant area and the positioning of this research in the area, (4) what will be elucidated, and to what extent and how will it be pursued during the research period, (5) preparation status towards achievement of the purpose of the research project., and (6) what sort of internationality this proposed research has (e.g. it will be a future world-leading research project, it will contribute to the development of global research projects through collaboration, it will create high value as a research project unique to Japan, etc.). If the proposed research project involves Co-Investigator(s) (Co-I(s)), a concrete description of the role-sharing between the Principal Investigator (PI) and the Co-I(s) should be given.

[SUMMARY]

Access to global academic opportunities hinges on how phraseological competence, particularly lexical bundles (LBs), enables dialogic fluency in second language (L2) use. Multi-word sequences (MWSs) are proven to lighten processing demands and strengthen fluency (Hougham et al., 2024a; Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020), yet studies have overwhelmingly centered on monologues, leaving dialogic use and extended LBs largely overlooked (Garner & Crossley, 2018; Zhang et al., 2021). This neglect is pressing, since dialogic performance is the core of success in high-stakes tests, such as IELTS and TOEFL, which directly determine pathways to higher education abroad (Cambridge Assessment, 2022). In line with Japan's push to expand student mobility (MEXT, 2018; 2023), this project investigates how LB length and frequency influence dialogic fluency across proficiency levels. Findings will improve fairness in international testing, enrich classroom practice, and ultimately empower Japanese learners of English with communicative competence that opens doors to global academic and professional futures.

(1) Scientific background of the proposed research, and the circumstances leading to the conception of the proposed research, and the key scientific question comprising the core of the research plan

Research on second language (L2) fluency has predominantly focused on monologic speech, leaving dialogic fluency—central to authentic interaction and high-stakes assessments—comparatively underexplored (Peltonen, 2017; Tavakoli & Wright, 2020). Multi-word sequences (MWSs), especially lexical bundles (LBs), facilitate fluency by lowering cognitive load and enabling faster, more automatic language production (Hougham et al., 2024a; Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020). Yet most studies have examined shorter LBs and monologic data, overlooking how LB length and usage shape fluency in interactional contexts (Garner & Crossley, 2018; Zhang et al., 2021). Dialogic fluency encompasses both within-turn phenomena (rate, pausing, repair) and between-turn coordination (turn-taking, responsiveness) (Peltonen, 2017; van Os et al., 2020), but operational definitions of these features remain underdeveloped and inconsistently validated. Existing evidence suggests dialogues may distribute planning effort across speakers, eliciting faster rates and fewer repairs than monologues, while introducing new demands for rapid, contextually appropriate responses (Tavakoli & Wright, 2020). Theoretical models of speech production (Levitt, 1989; Kormos, 2006; Skehan, 2014) predict that frequent, well-entrenched MWSs support such fluency by reducing formulation demands and mitigating trade-offs between complexity, accuracy, and fluency. However, the role of longer LBs remains unclear: while they may reduce mid-clause pauses, they can also increase end-clause pausing due to heavier planning needs (Hougham et al., 2024a). This project addresses these gaps by systematically examining how LB length and frequency predict dialogic fluency across proficiency levels.

These findings expose a critical disconnect between research and assessment practice: high-stakes tests such as IELTS and TOEFL dedicate up to 85% of speaking assessment to interactive, dialogic tasks, yet fluency rubrics remain anchored in monologic constructs (Cambridge Assessment, 2022). Current scoring penalizes pausing uniformly, failing to distinguish mid-clause dysfluency from strategic end-clause pausing linked to advanced LB use—potentially underestimating learners' true proficiency. While the literature confirms the role of MWSs in monologic L2 fluency, the dynamics of LB deployment in dialogue, especially for lower-proficiency speakers, remain underexplored (Hougham et al., 2024a; Tavakoli & Wright, 2020). Addressing the need for precise metric definitions and justified LB length thresholds is essential for advancing theoretical models and ensuring fairness and validity in high-stakes language assessment (Cambridge Assessment, 2022).

(1.1) "Key scientific question" comprising the core of the research plan

At the heart of the research plan lies a crucial scientific question: How does lexical bundle (LB) length and frequency affect dialogic fluency among L2 speakers across proficiency levels? Drawing on established fluency metrics (de Jong et al., 2012, 2013; Tavakoli & Skehan, 2005), the research will analyze within-turn phenomena (speed, breakdown, repair fluency) and between-turn dynamics (turn smoothness, responsiveness) to elucidate the impact of phraseological sophistication on real-time interaction. By integrating corpus-based analysis with psycholinguistic fluency measures, the project bridges theoretical models of L2 speech production with practical recommendations for assessment reform. The team brings extensive expertise spanning vocabulary measurement and acquisition (Booth & Clenton, 2020; Brooks, 2020; Brooks & Jordan, 2021; Clenton, 2010, 2015; Hollis & Leane, 2018), speaking proficiency and fluency (Brooks et al., 2021; Clenton, 2021; Hougham et al., 2023, 2024a; Wang-Taylor & Clenton, 2022), and the lexical characteristics of English production in relation to proficiency (Hollis & Takinami, 2023; Li et al., 2022; Myint Maw et al., 2022; Jordan, 2025), ensuring the research is grounded

[1. Research Objectives, Research Method, etc. (continued from the previous page)]
in robust methodological and theoretical frameworks.

(1.2) Research questions

Specifically, we will investigate the following three research questions:

- RQ1:** How does lexical bundle (LB) usage, differentiated by length, vary across proficiency levels in dialogic tasks?
- RQ2:** To what extent does LB length mediate the relationship between speed, breakdown, and repair fluency in dialogues?
- RQ3:** Do longer LBs more strongly predict dialogic fluency ratings (e.g., turn smoothness, responsiveness) than shorter LBs?

(2) Purpose, scientific originality, and creativity of the research project

This study targets critical gaps in L2 assessment, where high-stakes exams like IELTS and TOEFL emphasize dialogic tasks but assess them with monologic rubrics (Cambridge Assessment, 2022; ETS, 2023), neglecting the role of longer lexical bundles (LBs) in interactive fluency (Garner & Crossley, 2018; Zhang et al., 2021). The rubric development follows a three-stage process: (1) Threshold Setting—corpus analysis identifies LBs (4–8 words) with MI scores ≥ 3.0 and dispersion across interactions, refined through expert consultation (Biber & Barbieri, 2007); (2) Validation—certified examiners re-score dialogic performances using revised criteria, with inter-rater reliability assessed via Krippendorff's alpha (target $\alpha > .80$) and Many-Facet Rasch Measurement (MFRM) applied to examine rater and task effects; (3) Feasibility Testing—rubrics are piloted in examiner training, employing binary LB checklists based on examiner feedback to evaluate scoring consistency. By analyzing how LB length and MI scores predict fluency outcomes, the study offers practical solutions for assessment reform, including proposals for LB sophistication criteria that reflect real-time interactional competence (Peltonen, 2024; Cambridge Assessment, 2022). This aligns with MEXT's global readiness goals for Japanese learners (MEXT, 2018, 2023), and, by integrating cognitive and interactionist frameworks (Levitt, 1989; Long, 1996), advances theoretical models of dialogic fluency and sets a replicable standard for international assessment design.

This study advances L2 fluency research and assessment through three novel contributions.

1. Empirical innovation: It pioneers the systematic analysis of LB length as a predictor of dialogic fluency, moving beyond prior monologic-focused work (Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020; Zhang et al., 2021). While shorter LBs are linked to reduced mid-clause pausing (Hougham et al., 2024a), this project examines how longer bundles (5–8 words) shape both within-turn fluency (pause location, repair) and between-turn dynamics (transition speed), thus revealing cognitive–linguistic trade-offs in real-time interaction.

2. Methodological innovation: Combining advanced corpus analyses with psycholinguistic fluency metrics, the study integrates collocational strength (MI scores) with indicators such as pause duration and speech rate. This approach goes beyond frequency-based analyses to capture how entrenchment and predictability influence dialogic fluency (Garner & Crossley, 2018; Peltonen, 2024).

3. Theoretical contribution: By bridging usage-based (Ellis, 2002) and interactionist (Long, 1996) perspectives, the project proposes a model of dialogic fluency that incorporates cognitive retrieval processes and social coordination (Skehan, 2014; Robinson, 2011). It hypothesizes that longer LBs, though cognitively demanding, support strategic planning during turn transitions (Hougham et al., 2024), offering a mechanism overlooked in existing models.

Practically, these findings could reshape assessment rubrics in IELTS/TOEFL by distinguishing mid-clause dysfluency (penalized) from strategic end-clause pausing (rewarded), aligning with MEXT's priority of fostering global interactional competence (MEXT, 2018).

(3) Research trends in the relevant area and the positioning of this research in the area

This proposal responds to convergent global and domestic trends in L2 assessment and vocabulary research. International advances in computational linguistics, such as TAALES 2.0 and PRAAT, facilitate precise analysis of lexical sophistication and fluency metrics (Boersma & Weenink, 2005; Kyle et al., 2018), while corpus studies underscore the crucial role of multi-word expressions (MWEs) in oral fluency (Hougham et al., 2024a; Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020). The rise of AI-driven scoring systems further necessitates multidimensional, objective fluency measures reflecting authentic interaction (Saito et al., 2016; Suzuki et al., 2021). Domestically, MEXT policies emphasize equipping Japanese learners with interactional competence for global academia (MEXT, 2018), yet admissions tests like IELTS rely on rubrics misaligned with dialogic demands (Cambridge Assessment, 2022). This study integrates three strands: multidimensional vocabulary knowledge (Clenton, 2010; Fitzpatrick & Clenton, 2017), productive vocabulary-proficiency relationships (Clenton et al., 2021; Uchihara et al., 2022), and multi-word expression usage in learner corpora (Hougham et al., 2024a). Prior research highlights task-dependent variability in lexical diversity and fluency (Crowther et al., 2017), demonstrating the need for proficiency-sensitive frameworks. Leveraging corpus tools and fluency metrics, the project directly bridges gaps between monologic research and dialogic assessment, supporting MEXT's aim for globally ready graduates and answering calls to validate strategic lexical bundle (LB) use and task diversity in certification (Tavakoli et al., 2020).

This project occupies a pivotal space in L2 fluency and vocabulary research by bridging corpus linguistics, dialogic interaction, and assessment reform. While MWEs are known to facilitate fluency (Hougham et al., 2024a;

[1. Research Objectives, Research Method, etc. (continued from the previous page)]

Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020), the influence of LB length and sophistication on dialogic fluency, particularly in Japanese learners, remains underexplored (Clenton et al., 2021; Uchihara et al., 2022). Building on speech production (Levelt, 1989) and trade-off theories (Skehan, 2014), the study integrates usage-based (Ellis, 2012) and interactionist frameworks (Long, 2015) to examine how phraseological knowledge supports planning and turn-taking in real-time dialogue (Peltonen, 2023). Methodologically, it advances beyond monologic studies (Garner & Crossley, 2018) by applying tools such as TAALES 2.0 (Kyle et al., 2018) and PRAAT (Boersma & Weenink, 2023) to analyze LB usage across proficiency levels. The study aligns with global shifts toward automated, multidimensional fluency metrics in high-stakes exams where interactive speaking tasks dominate but are evaluated with largely monologic rubrics (Cambridge Assessment, 2022; Suzuki et al., 2021). Nationally, it supports MEXT’s goal of strengthening Japanese learners’ interactional competence (MEXT, 2018), addressing specific challenges in deploying sophisticated LBs under time pressure. By linking corpus-based vocabulary research (Clenton, 2015; Fitzpatrick & Clenton, 2017) with assessment reform, the project offers concrete ways to refine IELTS/TOEFL criteria and better recognize effective low-frequency vocabulary use.

(4) What will be elucidated, and to what extent and how will it be pursued during the research period

This study will establish empirical links between lexical bundle (LB) characteristics—length, frequency, and MI scores—and dialogic fluency outcomes (turn-taking efficiency, pause distribution, responsiveness) among Japanese L2 English speakers in high-stakes assessment contexts. By pinpointing threshold values at which longer LBs (5–8 words) transition from facilitating to hindering fluency, and mapping variation across proficiency levels (CEFR A2–C1), the research delivers precise, actionable metrics for learners and assessment systems. These insights will inform automated scoring algorithms, enabling differentiation between dysfluent hesitation and strategic planning pauses typical of advanced phraseological processing, thereby promoting fairer evaluation of interactive competence in international admissions. In addressing a major gap in current assessment frameworks, the study offers actionable guidance for language educators and test designers.

The study adopts a three-phase methodology to address key gaps in dialogic fluency research. First, we will compile a corpus of 120 L1 Japanese learners’ dialogic interactions, stratified by CEFR proficiency (A2–C1, 30 per level), ensuring sufficient statistical power for within- and between-group analyses as determined by a priori power analysis (G*Power 3.1). Multiple interactions per participant will enhance power for mixed-effects modelling. Dialogic tasks will use timed 30-second rotation to standardize interactivity and mitigate dominance (Saito et al., 2023). Speech will be transcribed via PRAAT, with inter-rater reliability verified on 20% of samples (Cohen’s $\kappa > .85$), excluding cases of excessive L1 interference. Second, lexical bundle analysis will employ TAALES 2.0 for collocation strength (MI scores) and Coh-Metrix for fluency metrics (mid-clause pauses, turn transitions), using linear mixed-effects models to assess LB length across proficiency and task type. Third, findings will be benchmarked against IELTS/TOEFL rubrics in expert workshops, with a subset of interactions re-scored using thresholds for LB sophistication; rubric validity will be evaluated via pre–post comparisons (paired t-test, $p < 0.05$). Potential biases, such as L1 transfer, will be mitigated by stratified sampling and outlier exclusion using standardized residuals (Nieuwenhuis et al., 2012). All protocols align with MEXT objectives and international standards for L2 fluency assessment (Cambridge Assessment, 2022; Hougham et al., 2024a).

(4.1) Methodology

This study employs a rigorous corpus-based design to examine dialogic fluency in 120 L1 Japanese L2 English learners, with comparison data from 50 L1 Vietnamese/Spanish learners to enhance cross-linguistic generalizability. The corpus will comprise 1,440 minutes of transcribed interactions (12 minutes per participant), stratified by CEFR proficiency (A2–C1) and sourced from pre-sessional courses in Japan and partner institutions. Tasks will use standardized IELTS-style prompts, piloted and rated for topic familiarity, and interactions managed via proficiency-matched pairings and 30-second timed turns (Saito et al., 2023). Recruitment will use stratified random sampling (proficiency, gender, study-abroad experience) with oversampling and quarterly monitoring to minimize attrition. Supplementary data from Trinity Lancaster and Vietnam National University corpora will provide additional dialogic contexts. All recordings will be transcribed with PRAAT; 20% dual-coded for inter-rater reliability (Cohen’s $\kappa > .85$), annotated for pause location and turn transitions. Lexical bundles will be analyzed with TAALES 2.0 (MI scores) and Coh-Metrix (lexical diversity), with fluency metrics (articulation rate, mid-clause pauses, turn transition latency) extracted via PRAAT. Linear mixed-effects models will assess relationships between LB metrics and fluency outcomes, mitigating overfitting by pre-registering model specifications (Open Science Framework), applying LASSO regularization, and maintaining effect-to-predictor ratios (1:20). Outliers will be excluded using standardized residuals and influence diagnostics; sample size sufficiency confirmed via G*Power (power=0.80, $\alpha=0.05$). Validation will involve certified IELTS examiners re-scoring samples with LB sophistication criteria, with consensus reached (Krippendorff’s $\alpha > .80$).

(4.2) Key to initials of Principal Investigator (PI) and Co-Investigators (Co-Is) on project timeline

CH = Christopher Hollis (Principal Investigator)	
JC = Jonathan Clenton (Co-Investigator)	DH = Daniel Hougham (Co-Investigator)
GB = Gavin Brooks (Co-Investigator)	JJ = Jennifer Jordan (Co-Investigator)

[1. Research Objectives, Research Method, etc. (continued from the previous page)]

(4.3) Project timeline

April 2026 – March 2027	April 2027 – March 2028	April 2028 – March 2029
Data Collection & Validation – Systematic sampling and transcription of dialogic spoken data from 300 L1 Japanese learners (stratified by CEFR level). (CH/GB/JJ) – Annotation using PRAAT; dual-coding 20% for inter-rater reliability. (CH/GB/DH) – Initial development of lexical bundle and collocation lists using TAALES 2.0 and Coh-Metrix. (CH/GB/JC) – Begin expert validation with international IELTS examiners and academic panels. (CH/JC)	Corpus Validation – Classroom-based validation of lexical bundle and collocation lists in Japan and overseas partner institutions. (CH/GB/DH) – Expand and balance corpus with additional recordings and texts. (CH/GB/JJ) – Statistical analysis to examine coverage and generalizability. (CH/DH/JC) – Present findings at Hiroshima Lexical Research Forum (H-LRF) and other conferences. (CH/all) – Refine methodology based on feedback. (CH/all)	Resource Development, Final Validation, Dissemination – Refine lists and develop digital learning tools and teaching materials. (CH/GB/DH/JC) – Final piloting and validation with L2 learners in Japan. (CH/JC/JJ) – Publish results in peer-reviewed journals (e.g., <i>Applied Linguistics</i>) and present at major conferences (e.g., <i>AAAL</i> , <i>BAAL</i>) (CH/all) – Open-access release of corpus, word lists, and tools via H-LRF, and partner platforms. (CH/JC/GB/DH) – Plan for future collaboration and research extension. (CH/all)

(5) Preparation status towards the achievement of the purpose of the research project

Our team is uniquely positioned to lead this research at the intersection of corpus linguistics, L2 fluency, and assessment reform. We have piloted dialogic datasets with Japanese learners, established standardized transcription and annotation protocols, and tested innovative metrics through PRAAT, Coh-Metrix, and TAALES 2.0. Building on prior contributions to vocabulary and phraseological research (Hougham et al., 2024a; Uchiyara et al., 2022), we have created robust dialogic tasks and turn-taking schemes suitable for large-scale data collection and cross-corpus comparability. To ensure methodological rigor and international impact, the project will extend existing collaborations with leading scholars in Japan (Waseda; Ritsumeikan), the UK (University of Reading; University of Nottingham/Lancaster), New Zealand (Victoria University of Wellington), and the US (University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign). Partnerships with certified IELTS examiners and assessment specialists will provide critical validation and ensure alignment with the demands of high-stakes contexts such as IELTS and TOEFL. By integrating cross-regional perspectives and complementary expertise, the project strengthens global capacity in operationalizing dialogic fluency, advancing both theoretical models and assessment practices in ways no single team could achieve.

(6) What sort of internationality this proposed research has

This study is designed for global impact by aligning dialogic fluency research with high-stakes language assessments, such as IELTS, which play vital roles in international education and workforce mobility (MEXT, 2018; J-MIRAI, 2023). To enhance international representation, we will proactively pursue new partnerships in regions where English proficiency is a strategic priority—beginning with exploratory outreach to leading ASEAN universities (e.g., Vietnam National University, Hanoi) and organizations such as the Vietnam National Foreign Languages Project (NFLP), guided by the British Council’s policy reports (2021). We will build connections with educational agencies in the Philippines and India, including initial consultations with the Department of Education and NCERT, to ensure our research encompasses varied pedagogical and linguistic contexts. Methodologically, our work synthesizes automated fluency assessment frameworks and recent advances in lexical bundle research (Hougham et al., 2024a; Tavakoli & Uchiyara, 2020; Cambridge Assessment, 2022). To promote transparency and open science, we will share dialogic corpora and analytic tools via Zenodo and ERIM, inviting international teams to participate in data-driven workshops and collaborative validation. Dissemination activities will focus on building new networks at conferences in underrepresented regions, such as SEAMEO-RELC and AsiaTEFL, with the aim of co-developing resources with partner institutions. By demonstrating how advanced fluency metrics enhance assessment validity, we provide a scalable evidence base to support educators and policymakers in tailoring instruction to diverse learner populations.

Concrete description of role sharing between the Principal Investigator and Co-Investigators

As Principal Investigator (PI), Christopher Hollis will oversee all stages of dialogic data collection, analysis, and dissemination, foster engagement with international experts, and lead publication in major applied linguistics journals. Co-Investigator (Co-I) Dan Hougham will coordinate dialogic task development, applying expertise in multi-word sequence measurement and statistical analysis. Co-I Jon Clenton will manage vocabulary assessment protocols and lexical diversity metrics, drawing on his substantial research background. Co-I Gavin Brooks will compile dialogic datasets, develop and maintain analysis scripts in Python and R, and supervise PRAAT annotation. Co-I Jennifer Jordan will coordinate data collection and contribute her expertise in multiword expressions. Working collaboratively, the team will ensure methodological rigor, analytical accuracy, and the effective dissemination of impactful research outputs.

2. Applicant's Ability to Conduct the Research and the Research Environment

Descriptions of (1) applicant's hitherto research activities (including main research achievements), and (2) research environments including research facilities and equipment, research materials, etc. relevant to the conduct of the proposed research should be given within 2 pages to show the feasibility of the research plan by the applicant (PI) (and Co-I(s), if any).
If the applicant has conducted any international efforts related to his/her research plan (such as his/her records of joint international research and research history in overseas institutions), they should be included as necessary in "(1) applicant's hitherto research activities". Also, if the applicant has taken leave of absence from research activity for some period, he/she may choose to write about it therein.

2.1 Applicant's hitherto research activities

The Principal Investigator (PI) and Co-Investigators (Co-Is) have published extensively in the following three areas:

2.1.1 *Vocabulary measures: The following research outputs highlight our academic experience that relates directly to measuring vocabulary knowledge and acquisition.*

- Booth, P., & Clenton, J. (Eds.). (2020). *First language influences on multilingual lexicons*. Routledge. (<https://doi.org/10.4324/9780429031410>)
- Booth, P., Clenton, J., & Van Herwegen, J. (2018). L1 – L2 semantic and syntactic processing: The influence of language proximity. *System*, 78, 54–64. Routledge. (<https://doi.org/10.17632/ryyxt8jhb8.1>)
- Brooks, G. (2020). Vocabulary usage in second language presentations. *JALT Post conference Publication 2019*, 1, 288–295. (JALT) (<https://doi.org/10.37546/JALTPCP2019-34>)
- Brooks, G., & Jordan, J. (2021). L2 vocabulary knowledge across modes of production: A pilot study. In P. Clements, R. Derrah, & P. Ferguson (Eds.), *Communities of teachers & learners* (pp. 1–8). JALT Japan. (<https://doi.org/10.37546/JALTPCP2020-22>)
- Edmonds, A., Clenton, J., & Elmetaher, H. (2022). Exploring the construct validity of tests used to assess L2 productive vocabulary knowledge, *System*, 108, 1–14. (Elsevier) (<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2022.102855>)
- Fitzpatrick, T., & Clenton, J. (2010). The challenge of validation: Assessing the performance of a test of productive vocabulary. *Language Testing*, 27(4), 537–554. (Sage) (<https://doi.org/10.1177/0265532209354771>)
- Fitzpatrick, T., & Clenton, J. (2017). Making sense of learner performance on tests of productive vocabulary knowledge, *TESOL Quarterly*, 51(4), 844–867. (Wiley) (<https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.356>)
- Hollis, C.J., & Leane, S. (2018). Incorrect Assumptions about Vocabulary Acquisition. *Tottori University Center for Liberal Arts Education Journal*, 14, p. 7-18. (https://repository.lib.tottori-u.ac.jp/record/2567/files/tuecb14_7.pdf) (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.16917532>)

2.1.2 *Vocabulary use: The following research outputs highlight our academic experience that relates directly to vocabulary and English language speaking proficiency and fluency.*

- Brooks, G., Clenton, J., & Fraser, S. (2021). Exploring the importance of vocabulary for English as an additional language learners' reading comprehension. *Studies in Second Language Learning and Teaching*, 11(3), 351–376. (<https://doi.org/10.14746/ssl.2021.11.3.3>)
- Brooks, G., Clenton, J., & Fraser, S. (2025). Exploring Potential Factors Affecting Reading Comprehension in EAL Learners: A Preliminary Corpus-Based Analysis. *Languages*, 10(2), 30. (<https://doi.org/10.3390/languages10020030>)
- Clenton, J., de Jong, H., Clingwall, D., & Fraser, S. (2021). Investigating the extent to which vocabulary knowledge and skills can predict aspects of fluency for a small group of pre-intermediate Japanese L1 users of English (L2). In J. Clenton & P. Booth (Eds.), *Vocabulary and the four skills* (pp. 126–145). Routledge. (Routledge/ Taylor and Francis) (<https://doi.org/10.4324/9780429285400>)
- Clenton, J. (2021). Vocabulary and speaking – future research, tools, and practice. In J. Clenton & P. Booth (Eds.), *Vocabulary and the four skills* (pp. 166–169). Routledge. (Routledge/ Taylor and Francis)
- Clingwall, D., Clenton, J., & Brooks, G. (2024). *Investigating oral fluency relationships for L1 Japanese learners of English*. Paper presented at the Hiroshima Lexical Research Forum, Hiroshima (2024).
- Hougham, D., Clenton, J., Uchihara, T., & Higginbotham, G. (2023, December). *How does learner use of longer MWSs relate to fluency?* Paper presented at the Vocab@Vic conference, Victoria University of Wellington, New Zealand. (<https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.16536.37122>)
- Hougham, D., Clenton, J., & Uchihara, T. (2024a). Disentangling the contributions of shorter vs. longer lexical bundles to L2 oral fluency. *System*, 121, 103243. (Elsevier) (<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2024.103243>)
- Hougham, D., Clenton, J., Uchihara, T., & Higginbotham, G. (2024b). The impact of lexical bundle length on L2 oral proficiency. *Languages*, 9(7), 232. (MDPI) (<https://doi.org/10.3390/languages9070232>)
- Uchihara, T., & Clenton, J. (2022). The role of spoken vocabulary knowledge in second language speaking proficiency. *The Language Learning Journal*, 51(3), 376–393. (Taylor and Francis) (<https://doi.org/10.1080/09571736.2022.2080856>)

[2. Applicant's Ability to Conduct the Research and the Research Environment (continued from the previous page)]

- Uchihara, T., Eguchi, M., & Clenton, J. (2022). The contribution of guessing from context and dictionary use to receptive and productive vocabulary knowledge: A structural equation modeling approach. *Language Teaching Research*. (Sage) (<https://doi.org/10.1177/13621688221122138>)
- Uchihara, T., Saito, K., & Clenton, J. (2020). Re-examining the relationship between productive vocabulary and second language oral ability. In J. Clenton & P. Booth (Eds). *Vocabulary and the four skills* (pp. 146-165). (Routledge/ Taylor and Frances) (<http://doi.org/10.4324/9780429285400-16>)
- Uchihara, T., Eguchi, M., Clenton, J., Kyle, K., & Saito, K. (2022). To what extent is collocation knowledge associated with oral proficiency? A corpus-based approach to word association. *Language and Speech*, 65(2), 311–336. (Sage) (<https://doi.org/10.1177/00238309211013865>)
- Wang-Taylor, Y., & Clenton, J. (2022). Exploring the relationship between L2 vocabulary size and academic speaking. *System*, 107. (Elsevier) (<http://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2022.102822>)
- Wang-Taylor, Y., Clenton, J. & Ren., Y. (2024). Investigating the impact of dialogic and triologic interactive factors on Chinese advanced L2 learners' vocabulary use in spoken contexts. *Languages*. (MDPI) (<https://doi.org/10.3390/languages9080266>)

2.1.3 Lexical characteristics of English and their relationship to proficiency: The following research outputs highlight our academic experience that relates directly to the lexical characteristics of vocabulary production.

- Clenton, J. (2010). Investigating the construct of productive vocabulary knowledge with Lex30. Unpublished thesis. Swansea University.
- Clenton, J. (2015). Testing the Revised Hierarchical Model: Evidence from word associations. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition*, 18(1), 118–125. (Cambridge University Press) (<https://doi.org/10.1017/S136672891400008X>)
- Clenton, J., Brooks, G., & Laufer, B. (2025). Vocabulary Studies in L1 and L2 Development: The Interface Between Theory and Practice. *Languages*, 10(4), 81. <https://doi.org/10.3390/languages10040081>
- Hollis, C.J., & Takinami, W. (2023). Vocabulary: Considerations and Applications in EFL Teaching. *Tottori University Journal of University Education Research*, 28, p. 97-104. (https://repository.lib.tottori-u.ac.jp/record/7646/files/jectu28_97.pdf) (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.16917708>)
- Jordan, J. (in press). *Lexical phrases in a learner corpus* [Doctoral dissertation]. Cardiff University.
- Li, Y., Fraser, S., & Clenton, J. (2022). Evaluating Jarvis and Hashimoto's operationalizations of word types and their influence on lexical diversity measures. *Hiroshima Studies in Language and Language Education*, 25, 109–120. (<https://doi.org/10.15027/51964>)
- Myint Maw, T., Clenton, J. & Higginbotham, G. (2022). Investigating whether a flemma count is a more distinctive measurement of lexical diversity, *Assessing Writing*, 53. (Elsevier) (<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.asw.2022.100640>)

2.2 Research environment

The research environment for this project is both robust and internationally networked, ensuring feasibility, innovation, and meaningful impact. Our collaborations with leading Japanese universities, including Hiroshima University and Kyoto Sangyo University, provide access to a large and diverse population of English-as-a-second-language learners, enabling the collection of rich and representative conversational data. These domestic partnerships are complemented by proposed international collaborations with institutions such as Massey University (New Zealand) and Vietnam National University (Vietnam), which allow for cross-cultural comparisons, external validation, and the generation of findings with broad educational relevance. In addition, the team benefits from ongoing collaboration with prominent scholars in applied linguistics and assessment, including Professors Treffers-Daller and Crossley, whose involvement strengthens methodological rigor and enhances the global dissemination of results. To ensure smooth implementation during extended data collection phases, we have established a tiered recruitment and training protocol for research assistants, with pre-identified backup candidates across partner institutions to safeguard continuity. Technical consistency will be achieved through the standardized use of high-quality recording equipment (e.g., Zoom H6n kits) and controlled acoustic conditions across all sites, minimizing variability in IELTS-style proctoring environments. Our research team brings deep expertise in advanced computational and analytic methods, including PRAAT, Python, R, and TAALES, equipping us to handle complex datasets with precision and innovation. Equally important, our infrastructure emphasizes ethical compliance, transparent data management, and the commitment to open-access dissemination, ensuring that outcomes are available to the wider academic and practitioner community. Active engagement with international research networks such as H-LRF (Hiroshima Lexical Research Forum) further amplifies our capacity for collaboration and knowledge exchange. Taken together, this integrated environment positions the project at the cutting edge of dialogic fluency research, providing not only the conditions for rigorous inquiry but also the potential to deliver resources and insights of lasting global value for L2 assessment and pedagogy.

3. Issues Relevant to the Protection of Human Right and Compliance with Laws and Regulations

(cf. Application Procedures for Grants-in-Aid for Scientific Research)

If the proposed research involves such issues that require obtaining the consent and/or cooperation of third parties, consideration in handling of personal information, or actions related bioethics and/or biosafety, including the laws, regulations and the guidelines in the country/region(s) where the joint international research is to be conducted, describe the measures and actions planned to be taken in responding to these issues within 1 page.

This provision applies to research activities that would require approval by an internal or external ethical jury, such as research involving handling of personal information from questionnaire surveys, interviews and/or behavior surveys, including personal histories and images, handling of donated specimens, human genome analysis, recombinant DNA, and experimentation with animals. If the activities of the proposed research do not fall under such categories, enter "N/A (not applicable)".

At all times, the researchers will follow the guidelines set out by MEXT and their respective institutions.
They will also follow the following guidelines for these specific parts of the research project:

Spoken corpora and validating the word lists: To participate in the study, each individual must sign a form consenting to the researcher's data usage plan and acknowledging that participation is voluntary and can be ended at any time. Personal identifying information will be removed from the data set before its public release. The Principal Investigator will apply for ethical clearance from Tottori University, Hiroshima University, Kyoto Sangyo University, and Kwansei Gakuin University for the research on human subjects.

When conducting an experiment with the participants, we will take the following measure to ensure that the participants involvement remains voluntary throughout: we will explain to participants prior to the study both verbally and in writing that the study bears no relation to their classwork and that even if the participants refuse to participate in the study or withdraw their consent to participation, they will experience no disadvantages, including those related to academic achievements. After the participants of the research receive explanations on the aforementioned items and before they express their consent, they will have opportunities to ask questions. We will present a document that includes the contact information of the principal investigator to respond to inquiries on the research from the participants. Even after the research is completed, participants will still be able to access the contact information. The document shall incorporate the contact information for the 非医学系研究倫理審査委員会 (Non-Medical Research Ethics Review Board) at Tottori University's Center for Liberal Arts Education, where the research participants can clarify any questions on research content that they do not want to reveal to the principal investigator. The document will clearly state that the participants who have contacted the consultation desk will suffer no disadvantages. As this project is expected to be mutually beneficial, Kyoto Sangyo University coordinators and teachers have expressed support and a willingness to facilitate data collection. In consideration of protecting personal information, all data will be initially anonymized before being entered into the original corpus. In addition, prior to publication, papers will be specifically checked to ensure that none of the information relates to any individual. All the researchers on the team fully understand these requests and the necessity of handling personal information with care.

In our previous research projects, we have experience collecting data from students while ensuring that the data collection meets the institution's ethical requirements and does not disrupt the students' learning environment. We will continue to consult with the relevant ethics committees at our institution to ensure all relevant ethical guidelines are being met. In addition, all members of the team have all successfully completed the JSPS e-learning ethics course. Participants, including students, instructors, and educators, will be notified that they have the option to withdraw from the study at any time without facing any repercussions.

4. Items to be Entered When New Application is Made in the Fiscal Year Previous to the Final Year of the Research Period of an On-Going KAKENHI Project

(For an application that comes under this category, this column is a mandatory entry. (cf. Application Procedures for Grants-in-Aid for Scientific Research))

The applicant should give within 1 page: (1) the relevant information on the on-going project (for which FY2026 is the final year of the research period) including the original plan at the time of application/adoption and the research accomplishment such as new knowledge acquired, and (2) the reason why he/she is submitting this new proposal for FY2026 on top of the on-going project (in terms of the development of the on-going research, necessity of new research budget, etc.). If not applicable, leave this page blank. (Do not delete the page.)

Research Category	Project Number	Title of the Research Project	Research Period
			FY__ to FY2026

The original plan at the time of application/adoption and the research accomplishment of the on-going project.

The reason for submission of this new proposal.